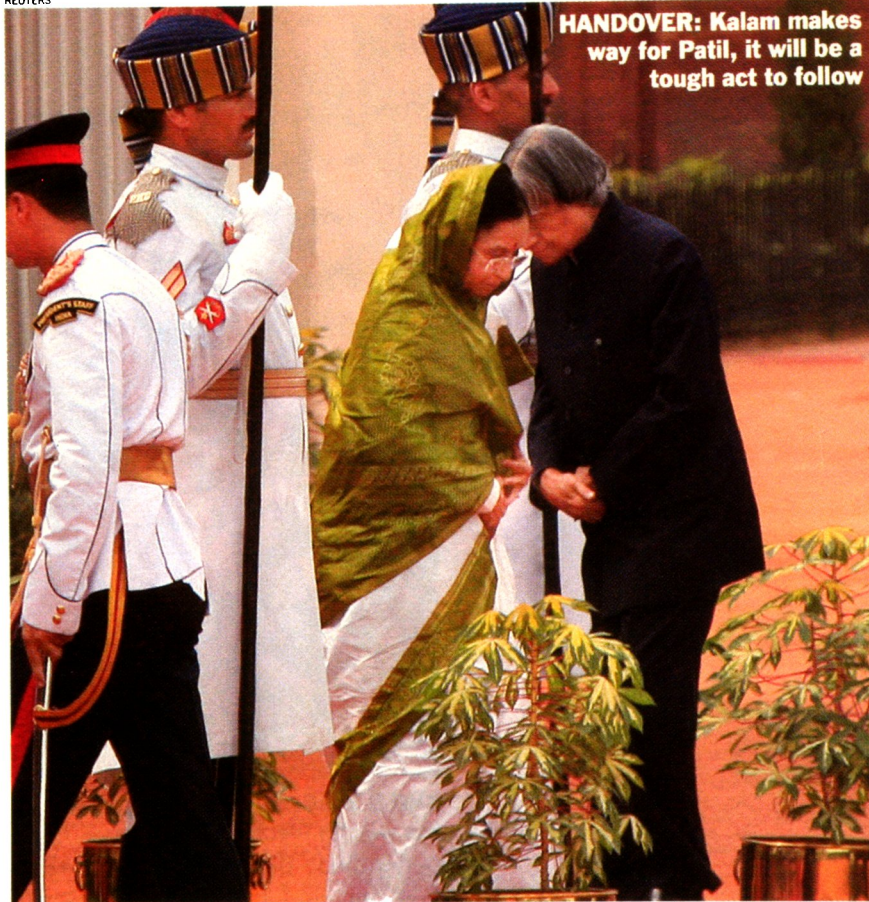


REUTERS



HANDOVER: Kalam makes way for Patil, it will be a tough act to follow

demonstrated that he was no novice. He brought with him all the experience he had gathered serving six prime ministers. He got along well with both Vajpayee and Manmohan maintaining his independence without becoming an activist President. As one political leader remarked, "He was neither an activist nor a rubber stamp."

While Kalam maintained a balance, he also brought with him an agenda for development that he fiercely marketed right through his presidency. He knew that no prime minister or party could complain if he talked of how to make the nation economically developed by 2020. So he cleverly used that advantage to propagate his message and ideals wherever he went. His main contribution has been the proposal of propagating PURA (Providing Urban Amenities in Rural Areas), a roadmap

for bridging the rural-urban divide and one of his pet themes. For Kalam, Bharat and India were inseparable and the key to development lies in bringing them closer. He has also been pushing for a Pan-African e-network connecting 53 countries and the World Knowledge Platform.

In Delhi not only did he give parliamentarians a PowerPoint presentation about his vision but also addressed 14 state legislatures on the subject. When he visited 16 countries during his presidency, he also took along with him his laptop and made PowerPoint presentations to the leaders he met there. In Zurich in 2005, 12 Nobel laureates came to hear him. So impressed was the Swiss Government by his credentials that it declared the day of his visit, May 26, the national science day. And in Singapore when he made a presentation, a former prime minister of the

country remarked that he had never seen the head of a nation make a PowerPoint presentation.

In October, Kalam will turn 76, but he shows no signs of ageing (he still does not need reading glasses) and is bursting with energy. He is already into what he describes as his "next mission"—of spreading the message of development and says "my plate is full". More than anything else, Kalam brought to the Rashtrapati Bhavan a style and approach that was totally at odds with conventional practice and protocol. In many ways, he was an oddity in Indian political life, but that is precisely what endeared him to millions and, ultimately, denied him a second term. To the ruling establishment, a pliable politician is a better option than a rebel, a thinker and an "outsider".

Kalam leaves a legacy that no President before him has left. By combining modernity and idealism, he proved that the presidential post was also a platform for providing leadership and practical vision. He was also, during those five years, a personification of secularism. As former Karnataka chief minister Dharam Singh remarks, "President Kalam brought a whole new meaning to secularism. A man who could sing Tyagaraja *kritis*, play the veena and read the Bhagavad Gita and the Koran with equal fervour, he symbolised the true Indian."

Kalam believes that the President of India can play a much greater role in the affairs of the State. "If he thinks big, he can. The post does not restrict the person at all," he says. It certainly didn't in his case. As Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi puts it, "He spoke from his heart and whenever he expressed his concern about a problem, he appeared genuine. A star has left Rashtrapati Bhavan." The final word comes from the man who tried to get him re-elected, former Andhra Pradesh chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, "He represents a defining moment in Indian democracy."

Five years after, and with an uninspiring choice as his successor, there are only two words that can sum up the nation's farewell message. "Thank you, Mr President."

"Kalam represents a DEFINING moment in Indian DEMOCRACY."

N. CHANDRABABU NAIDU, FORMER ANDHRA PRADESH CHIEF MINISTER